Leadership Tool: How To Ask Engaging, Humble, and Appreciative Questions During Coaching

In the realm of leadership coaching, the concept of humble inquiry, as introduced by Edgar Schein, offers a transformative approach to communication that fosters deeper connections and promotes meaningful development. Schein defines humble inquiry as "the fine art of drawing someone out, of asking questions to which you do not already know the answer, of building a relationship based on curiosity and interest in the other person." This approach shifts the focus from the coach as the expert to the coachee as the central figure in the conversation, encouraging an environment where the coachee feels heard, respected, and valued. In leadership and coaching contexts, humble inquiry is especially relevant because it breaks down hierarchical barriers, enabling a more collaborative and trust-based relationship. By genuinely seeking to understand the coachee's perspective, experiences, and challenges, coaches can create a safe space where authentic dialogue and growth can occur.

Trust is the foundation of any effective coaching relationship, and it is established when the coachee feels that the coach is genuinely interested in their thoughts, feelings, and experiences. Humble questions, which are open-ended and non-judgmental, invite the coachee to share openly without fear of being judged or misunderstood. This type of questioning demonstrates the coach's commitment to understanding the coachee's unique situation and challenges, rather than imposing preconceived solutions or judgments. As a result, the coachee is more likely to engage deeply in the coaching process, leading to more authentic insights and breakthroughs.

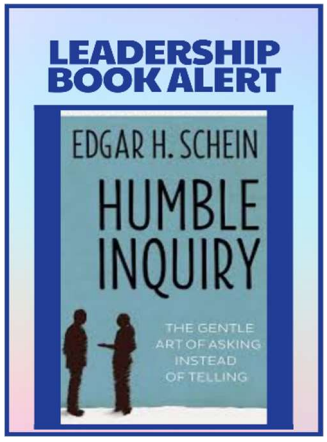
Furthermore, humble inquiry leads to deeper understanding and more effective coaching outcomes. When coaches employ humble questions, they encourage coachees to reflect more deeply on their situations, which often uncovers underlying issues, motivations, and aspirations that might not have been initially apparent. This process of reflection can lead to greater self-awareness and clarity, empowering the coachee to take ownership of their development and make informed decisions. Additionally, the collaborative nature of humble inquiry ensures that the solutions and strategies developed during coaching sessions are tailored to the coachee's specific needs and context, increasing the likelihood of successful implementation and long-term impact. Ultimately, by utilizing humble questions, coaches can enhance the coaching process, fostering not only personal growth but also leadership effectiveness in their coachees.

Utilizing Humble Questions to Build Trust

Humble questions—those that are open-ended and non-judgmental—help to establish a psychologically safe space where coachees feel comfortable expressing themselves freely. When a coach engages in humble inquiry, they invite the coachee to share their thoughts, feelings, and

concerns without fear of judgment or criticism. This type of questioning not only signals to the coachee that their perspective is valued, but it also encourages them to explore their thoughts more deeply, fostering a sense of safety and openness in the coaching relationship. By reducing the perceived risks of vulnerability, humble inquiry allows coachees to engage more fully in the coaching process, leading to more authentic and productive conversations.

Additionally, humble inquiry fosters mutual respect between the coach and the coachee, which is essential for a successful coaching relationship. By asking questions that seek to understand rather than to impose, the coach demonstrates respect for the coachee's knowledge, experiences, and emotions. This approach acknowledges that the coachee is the expert in their own life and work, and that their insights are valuable in the coaching process. When a coach approaches conversations with humility, it reduces the power dynamics that often exist in coaching relationships, making the coachee feel more equal and valued. This respect for the coachee's autonomy not only strengthens the relationship but also empowers the coachee to take ownership of their development, which is a key factor in achieving meaningful and lasting change.



When a coach adopts a humble stance, they shift the focus from being the authority figure to being a facilitator of the coachee's growth. This shift is critical because it allows the coachee to feel more engaged and invested in the process. Humility in coaching encourages a collaborative environment where both parties learn from each other, and where the coachee's contributions are seen as integral to the coaching journey. This approach not only enhances the effectiveness of the coaching but also builds a relationship based on trust, respect, and mutual growth, which are essential components of any successful leadership development effort. By utilizing humble inquiry, coaches can create a dynamic and supportive space where coachees are empowered to explore, grow, and ultimately lead more effectively.

Types of Humble Questions in Coaching

Open-Ended Questions

Definition and Importance: Open-ended questions are inquiries that cannot be answered with a simple "yes" or "no." These questions are designed to allow coachees to express themselves freely, providing a broader scope for sharing thoughts, feelings, and experiences. In a coaching context, open-ended questions are essential as they encourage reflection, deeper thinking, and a comprehensive exploration of the coachee's perspectives and challenges. By avoiding leading questions, the coach can ensure that the coachee feels heard and validated, which fosters a more meaningful dialogue.

Best Practice: When using open-ended questions, it's important to listen actively and be patient with pauses in the conversation. This allows the coachee time to think and respond thoughtfully, rather than rushing to fill the silence. Additionally, open-ended questions should be asked so that the coach can better understand and learn from the perspective of the coachee. Leading questions would not be considered humble questions because the coach is not looking to learn from the answers.

Examples:

1. "Can you walk me through what happened during that situation?"
2. "How do you feel about the challenges you're currently facing?"
3. "What are some of the outcomes you hope to achieve from this experience?"

Clarifying Questions

Definition and Importance: Clarifying questions are used to ensure that the coach fully understands what the coachee is communicating. These questions help prevent assumptions and misinterpretations by allowing the coachee to elaborate on their thoughts or clarify any ambiguous statements. Clarifying questions are crucial in coaching because they ensure both parties are on the same page, which is necessary for effective communication and problem-solving.

Best Practice: When asking clarifying questions, it's important to frame them in a way that is non-judgmental. This approach helps in making the coachee feel that their perspective is valid and worth exploring further.

Examples:

1. "When you mentioned feeling overwhelmed, can you specify what exactly is contributing to that feeling?"
2. "Could you elaborate on what you mean by 'difficult to manage' in your current role?"
3. "Can you clarify what success would look like for you in this scenario?"

Probing Questions

Definition and Importance: Probing questions are designed to delve deeper into a coachee's thoughts, emotions, and motivations. These questions often follow up on the coachee's initial responses to encourage further reflection and discovery. Probing questions play a critical role in coaching by helping the coachee uncover underlying issues, assumptions, and beliefs that may not be immediately apparent. This depth of exploration can lead to greater self-awareness and insight, which are key to personal growth and development.

Best Practice:
It's essential to use probing questions with sensitivity. The coach should be mindful of the coachee's emotional state and readiness to explore deeper issues, ensuring that the questions do not feel intrusive or overwhelming.

Examples:

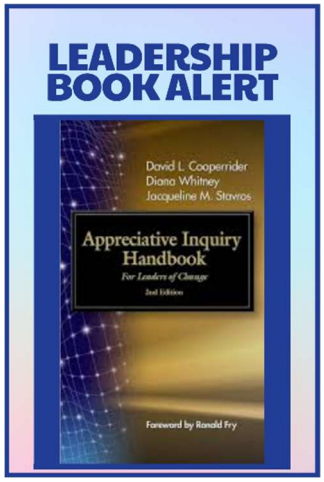
1. "What do you think is the root cause of your hesitation in making this decision?"
2. "How do you think your past experiences are influencing your current approach to this problem?"
3. "What underlying fears or concerns might be contributing to your reluctance to take action?"

Leadership Tip!

When Asking Probing Questions
Incorporate the word "exactly" into your questions to get more precise information: "What exactly do you mean by leveraging synergy? " or "Who exactly was part of the decision making process?"

Appreciative Inquiry

Definition and Importance: Appreciative Inquiry (AI) involves asking questions that focus on what is working well in a coachee's life or organization. Instead of concentrating on problems, AI seeks to identify and build upon strengths, successes, and positive experiences. In a coaching setting, Appreciative Inquiry helps shift the coachee's mindset towards a more positive and constructive approach to challenges, fostering a sense of possibility and optimism.



Best Practice: When using Appreciative Inquiry, it's crucial to frame questions in a way that highlights past successes and envisions future possibilities. This approach not only builds confidence but also motivates the coachee to leverage their strengths in tackling current challenges.

Examples:

1. "Can you tell me about a time when you successfully navigated a similar challenge?"
2. "What are the strengths that have helped you achieve your past successes?"
3. "How can you apply what worked well in previous situations to your current challenge?"

Common Challenges

Practicing humble inquiry in coaching often comes with several challenges that can hinder its effectiveness. One of the most prevalent challenges is time constraints. In a fast-paced environment, coaches and leaders might feel pressured to get quick answers or rush through conversations, which undermines the depth of inquiry necessary for meaningful dialogue. Additionally, preconceived notions can cloud judgment, leading coaches to make assumptions or jump to conclusions before fully understanding the coachee's perspective. Another significant challenge is discomfort with silence. Many leaders feel the urge to fill pauses in conversation with their own thoughts or solutions, rather than allowing the coachee time to reflect and respond. This tendency to offer solutions rather than asking questions can stifle the coachee's opportunity for self-discovery and limit the effectiveness of the coaching process.

Strategies for Overcoming Challenges

To overcome these challenges, it is essential for coaches to cultivate patience and curiosity in their practice. One effective technique is to consciously slow down the pace of the conversation, ensuring that both the coach and coachee have the time to engage deeply with the questions being asked. Embracing the discomfort of silence is also crucial; by pausing and waiting for the coachee to respond, coaches signal that they value the coachee's thoughts and are genuinely interested in their perspective. Active listening plays a critical role here as well—by fully concentrating on the coachee's words without interrupting or formulating a response prematurely, coaches can better understand the nuances of the coachee's experiences and feelings.

Active listening and pausing are fundamental to practicing humble inquiry effectively. Active listening involves not just hearing the words the coachee says, but also paying attention to their tone, body language, and underlying emotions. This level of engagement helps the coach to ask more insightful follow-up questions and to respond in a way that acknowledges the coachee's experience. Pausing, on the other hand, allows the coachee time to think and articulate their thoughts more clearly. It also gives the coach an opportunity to process what has been said, rather than jumping to conclusions or offering premature advice. By integrating these practices, coaches can foster a more thoughtful and empowering coaching experience that aligns with the principles of humble inquiry.

Conclusion

Humble inquiry plays a pivotal role in various coaching contexts, particularly in performance improvement and career development. In performance improvement coaching, humble questions enable coaches to uncover hidden challenges and strengths by encouraging coachees to reflect deeply on their experiences. By asking open-ended questions such as, "What factors contributed to this outcome?" or "How can you leverage your strengths to overcome this challenge?" coaches facilitate self-reflection that leads to actionable insights and enhanced performance. This approach not only helps coachees understand their current performance levels but also empowers them to identify steps for future improvement.

In career development coaching, humble inquiry serves as a powerful tool for exploring a coachee's long-term aspirations and motivations. By asking thoughtful questions like, "What are your career goals for the next five years?" or "What aspects of your work inspire you the most?" coaches can guide coachees through a process of self-discovery, helping them to clarify their goals and chart a path toward achieving them. This method fosters a sense of ownership and purpose in coachees, motivating them to take proactive steps in their career journey. Whether it's enhancing performance, planning a career path, or developing leadership qualities, humble inquiry provides a foundation for meaningful growth and development in any coaching relationship.

References:

Schein, E. H., & Schein, P. A. (2021). *Humble inquiry: The gentle art of asking instead of telling*. Berrett-Koehler Publishers.